Orbán

The Origin of European Right-Wing Populism







Rise of a Populist

Following the fall of soviet power within late 1980s Hungary led a democratic transition, commonly referred to in Hungarian as Rendszerváltás (system change). In this campaign students at universities banded together to form an organization, later party, the Alliance of Young Democrats (**FI**atal **DE**mokraták **SZ**övetsége, or FIDESZ), led by Orbán Viktor. Standing in opposition to the dominant Socialist Party (MSZP) for many years, even gaining majority and ruling as Prime Minister from 1998-2002. This showed the will at the time toward Fidesz's Nationalist Liberal policies, during which the country joined NATO. After returning to the opposition, FIDESZ did not return to rule until a series of scandals by the MSZP, which lead Fidesz to a ruling victory in 2010 after joining in coalition with the Christian democrat party (KDNP), from where it took a harder center-right approach, loosing the young democrat branding, to better oppose the MSZP, and emerging harder right factions (ie. Jobbik).

Illiberal Democracy

The continual shift of FIDESZ to the right, were joined by an increased number of corruption cases and favors to party officials. In 2010 with FIDESZ-KDNP majority they were able to amend the Hungarian constitution to change the electoral system making it harder for opposition win. By using old soviet era frameworks the allies of Orbán were able to gain control of government services and contracts. Enriching themselves to buy public media corporations and companies that then support the Orbán regime. This change in the media and electoral landscape has dubbed Hungary an "Illiberal Democracy" which is a claim Orbán himself wears with pride.

The Establishment

The first set of "Elites" Orbán and FIDESZ rallied the people against in its formation was the ruling soviet communist and later socialist party elites, which where helped by rampant corruption from all sides of the aisle, which Orban was loud to point out against the Socialist party and its leader Gurcsány Ferenc. Its further shift to the right made enemies out of democratic institutions from which it initially gained support, becoming increasingly Eurosceptic. Fueled by the migrant crisis in the middle 2010s the Hungarian government became increasingly anti-immigration. Villainizing any organization that was against FIDESZ party policy, seeing these as enacting a will upon the Hungarian people villainizing the likes of George Soros and EU officials.

Pictured: Orban in 1988, Fidesz Logo, Orban today, Flag of EU, Ursula Von der Leyen, George Soros

Bibliography

Hoffmann, T., & Gárdos-Orosz, F. (2022, March 8). Populism and Law in Hungary – Introduction to the Special Issue. *Review of Central and East European Law, 47*(1), pp. 1-11. doi:10.1163/15730352-bja10058

Mudde, C., & Kaltwasser, C. R. (2017). *Populism: A Very Short Introduction.* Oxford University Press.

Végh, Z. (2016, September 1). Hungary: The EU's troublemaker. *Keeping Europeans Together: Assessing the state of EU Cohesion*, pp. 72-75. Retrieved from https://www.jstor.org/stable/resrep21671.17